had been on a trek in Sikkim with Princess Coocoola to survey the terrain. On his return to India, he contacted India's then spymaster, Bhola Nath Mullik, who was more steeped in the old colonial tradition than Nehru, a progressive politician. Contacts were made with two of the Dalai Lama's brothers then living in exile. The elder of the two, Thubten Norbu, already had CIA contacts through an obscure outfit called the Committee for a Free Asia. The younger, Gyalo Thondup, had settled in Darjeeling. Kalimpong, which was nearby, and on the main line of communication between India and Tibet, became a hub of covert activity, from where agents were sent across the border to collect intelligence on 'enemy troops movements' and local guerrillas resisting the Chinese occupation of Tibet were armed.[102]

By 1956, the Khampa rebellion was sweeping across eastern Tibet, and a group of warlike Khampas had congregated in Kalimpong. Getting them out of India posed a major problem, as Nehru and his government would have to be kept in the dark. But there was a way: across the narrow neck of Indian territory between Bhutan and East Pakistan. By the mid-1950s, Pakistan had become a close ally of the United States and would be more welcoming than neutral India to secret proposals from Washington. In 1954, Pakistan had joined an anti-communist defence organization called the Southeast Asia Treaty Organisation (SEATO), which included Australia, New Zealand, France, Thailand, and the Philippines, apart from the United States. In 1955, a parallel alliance had been formed in West Asia: the Central Treaty Organisation (CENTO), which brought together Britain, Iran, Iraq, Turkey—and Pakistan.

Then, in March 1959, an uprising broke out in Lhasa against Chinese occupation. The Dalai Lama had been invited by the Chinese to attend a theatrical performance at the PLA's military headquarters on the outskirts of Lhasa. He was advised not to bring his traditional armed escort, which made him and his men deeply suspicious. They suspected that the Chinese intended to abduct the Dalai Lama, and words to that effect spread throughout Lhasa. Thousands of people surrounded the Dalai Lama's palace to prevent him from leaving or being taken away by the Chinese.

On 12 March, people appeared on the streets of Lhasa, re-declaring Tibet's independence and fighting broke out between the PLA and Tibetan resistance forces. The PLA responded by deploying artillery pieces within range of Norbulingka, the Dalai Lama's summer palace. On 17 March, two